# Bharat Jodo and Civil Society

*Hrishikesh Singh*

## Planning the Yatra

Looking back at the Bharat Jodo Yatra almost a year since it wrapped up feels surreal, almost as if I were revisiting a fantasy. Did we really walk almost 4,000 kilometres? Did I really manage to walk from Kanyakumari to Kashmir? In fact, what I recall most distinctly is how incredulous I was when I heard that the Yatra would be conducted after the Indian National Congress's Jaipur session. Having worked as a political activist for almost a decade, my first instinct was that this would prove to be an ill-fated experiment and would just mean a diversion of precious time and resources. Plus, it was perhaps a weak response to the sorry state of India's contemporary political situation. But as a loyal Congressman, another voice inside my head kept nagging me to defer to the wisdom of my party leadership. In that spirit, I kept thinking back to the electoral impact of former chief minister Digvijaya Singh's Narmada Yatra and reconciled myself to the possibility of the BJY having a similar outcome.

Over time, escalating coverage of the impending Yatra in the media intensified my interest and enthusiasm towards what was being described as a pilgrimage. Then, out of the blue, on 20 August 2022, Gurdeep Singh Sappal, who had taken on the responsibility of coordinating with civil society on behalf of the Congress party, extended an invitation for my participation in the Bharat Jodo Yatra. At the same time, he delegated the Samruddha Bharat Foundation (SBF) to coordinate the entire process, since he would be busy with other party work. I was thrilled to be asked to support the Yatra in some capacity, even though my apprehensions about